much in doubt: Fighter planes couldn't fly and warships couldn't sail because there were chronic shortages of spare parts; our best men and women were leaving the military service; the morale of our volunteer army was in a tailspin; our strategic weapons—the missiles and bombers that were the foundations of our deterrent force—hadn't been modernized in a decade, while the Soviet Union had created a war machine that was threatening to eclipse ours at every level.

I wanted to go to the negotiating table and end the madness of the MAD policy, but to do that, I knew America first had to upgrade its military capabilities so that we would be able to negotiate with the Soviets from a position of *strength*, not weakness.

Now, our military might was second to none. In 1981, we undertook a massive program to rebuild our military might while I began an effort—much of it through quiet diplomacy—that I hoped would lead the Russians to the bargaining table.

I knew very well the Soviet Union's record of deceit and its long history of betrayal of international treaties. I had met Gromyko. I had met Brezhnev. I knew every Communist leader since Lenin was committed to the overthrow of democracy and the free enterprise system. I knew about this strategy of deceit from personal experience: Many years before, I'd gone head to head with Communists who were intent on taking over our country and destroying democracy.

I knew there were great differences between our two countries. Yet the stakes were too high for us not to try to find a common ground where we could meet and reduce the risk of Armageddon.

For more than five years, I'd made little progress with my efforts at quiet diplomacy—for one thing, the Soviet leaders kept dying on me. But when we arrived in Geneva, I felt that